

useless. He went on to build his giant machines and the nation's biggest earth-moving-machinery company—and to revolutionize the entire heavy-construction industry.

Reaching 65 in 1953, LeTourneau sold his business to Westinghouse Air Brake for a reported \$31,000,000. He also agreed not to engage in manufacturing earth-moving machinery for the next five years. The consensus held that it would not be possible for him to get back into business again—not only because of his age, but also because he gave most of his money to a charitable foundation.

LeTourneau confounded the consensus, however. By 1959—

at the age of 71—he was right back in business. He produced a revolutionary electrically powered, mobile offshore oil-drilling platform which, incidentally, the wiseacres had maintained "never could be built and

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wouldn't work even if it was." At last report, Robert LeTourneau's sales were said to be running in the neighborhood of \$10,000,000 a year.

Few people, indeed, considered the Depression-era year of 1933 an auspicious one in which to start a new business.

Among those who thought otherwise was young J. A.

Ryder, who turned a deaf ear to the calamity howlers'

warnings that any new business was bound to fail. Using \$125 of his \$155 "capital," Ryder bought a secondhand truck and went into business for himself. With an almost uncanny talent for perceiving the possible in the most unpromising times and situations, he went on to build his business. Within 25 years, he had created a trucking empire with an annual gross revenue that is said to exceed \$85,000,000.

Shortly before V-E Day, First Lieutenant Melvin J.